

WEEK 21

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 4:17 – 24*

Clothe yourselves with the new man.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

Now this I affirm and testify in the Lord, that you must no longer live as the Gentiles do, in the futility of their minds; they are darkened in their understanding, alienated from the life of God because of the ignorance that is in them, due to their hardness of heart; they have become callous and have given themselves up to licentiousness, greedy to practice every kind of uncleanness.

You did not so learn Christ! -- Assuming that you have heard about him and were taught in him, as the truth is in Jesus. Put off your old nature, which belongs to your former manner of life and is corrupt through deceitful lusts, and be renewed in the spirit of your minds, and put on the new nature, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.

Responsorial. *Ep. 4, 23 – 24; Col. 3, 9. 10*

R: You have to renew your minds in the Spirit and clothe yourselves with the new man, * created according to God in justice and in true holiness.

V: You have undressed yourself of the old man with his actions; dress yourself with the new man,

R: created according to God in justice and in true holiness.

Second Reading. *Disc. 59: 2 – 4*

The baptism of our Lord is our burial.

A reading from the “Discourses” of St. Maximus of Turin, bishop.

We read in the Scriptures that the salvation of all the human race was acquired with the blood of the Saviour, as the apostle Peter says: “not with the price of corruptible things, like silver and gold were we freed... but with the precious blood of Christ, like a lamb without defects and without stain”

(1 Pt. 1, 18. 19). If therefore the price of our life is the blood of the Lord, you see how not only the earthly fragility of the field has been ransomed, but the eternal salvation of all the world; the evangelist in fact says that Christ did not come “To judge the world, but so that the world could be saved through him” (Jn. 3, 17).

You will ask me perhaps that if the field is the world, who could be the potter who was able to exercise his dominion on the world. If I am not mistaken, the potter is he himself who forms with earth the vases of our bodies, as the Scriptures says: “The Lord God formed man with the dust of the earth” (Gn. 2, 7). He is the potter who created us with his own hands for life, and through his Christ has recreated us for glory, as the apostle says: “we are transformed into that same image, of glory in glory” (2 Cor. 3, 18); that is, we because of our sins have become decadent of our original condition, in the second birth we are repaired by the mercy of this potter; we who participate in the death through the disobedience of Adam, rise again through the grace of the Saviour.

The field of the potter is bought by the blood of Christ for foreigners; for foreigners, I say, who, deprived of house and without country, were thrown as exiles into all the world; their rest is procured by the blood of Christ, so that they who do not possess anything on earth, find burial in Christ. Who therefore are these pilgrims if not the most fervent Christians, who renouncing to the world and to any possession, find peace in the blood of Christ? In fact the Christian who does not possess at all the world, possesses entirely the Saviour.

To the foreigners then is promised the burial of Christ, in the sense that he who knows how to abstain from the desires of the flesh as a foreigner and pilgrim, will merit the peace of Christ. In fact what is the burial of Christ if not the peace of the Christian? We are therefore pilgrims in this world and we live as guests on the earth, according to the words of the Apostle who says: “As long as we live in this body we are in exile far away from the Lord” (2 Cor. 5, 6). We are foreigners, I say, and our burial has been bought at the price of the blood of the Saviour.

“Through baptism, says the Apostle, we have been buried together with him in death” (Rm. 6, 4). Therefore the baptism of the Lord is our burial: in it we die to sin, it is as if we are buried to sin and the nature of the interior old man being transformed in a second birth, we are brought back to a new infancy.

The baptism of the Saviour is our burial, because in it we are undressed of the life that we have lived in order to receive a new life. Great therefore is the grace of this burial, in which is inferred a beneficial death and a more just life is conceded as a gift; really great is the grace of this burial, which at the same time purifies the sinner and vivifies he who is dead.

Responsorial. *Rm. 6, 4. 3*

R: Through baptism we have been buried together with him in death, * because as Christ was raised from the dead by means of the glory of the Father, so also we can walk in a new life.

V: In as much as we have been baptised in Christ Jesus, we have been baptised in his death,

R: because as Christ was raised from the dead by means of the glory of the Father, so also we can walk in a new life.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Titus 1: 1 – 16*

The mission of Titus.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Titus.

Paul, a servant of God and an apostle of Jesus Christ, to further the faith of God's elect and their knowledge of the truth which accords with godliness, in hope of eternal life which God, who never lies, promised ages ago and at the proper time manifested in his word through the preaching with which I have been entrusted by command of God our Saviour; To Titus, my true child in a common faith: Grace and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Saviour.

This is why I left you in Crete, that you might amend what was defective, and appoint elders in every town as I directed you, if any man is blameless, the husband of one wife, and his children are believers and not open to the charge of being profligate or insubordinate. For a bishop, as God's steward, must be blameless; he must not be arrogant or quick-tempered or a drunkard or violent or greedy for gain, but hospitable, a lover of goodness, master of himself, upright, holy, and self-controlled; he must hold firm to the sure word as taught, so that he may be able to give

instruction in sound doctrine and also to confute those who contradict it. For there are many insubordinate men, empty talkers and deceivers, especially the circumcision party; they must be silenced, since they are upsetting whole families by teaching for base gain what they have no right to teach. One of themselves, a prophet of their own, said, "Cretans are always liars, evil beasts, lazy gluttons." This testimony is true. Therefore rebuke them sharply, that they may be sound in the faith, instead of giving heed to Jewish myths or to commands of men who reject the truth.

To the pure all things are pure, but to the corrupt and unbelieving nothing is pure; their very minds and consciences are corrupted. They profess to know God, but they deny him by their deeds; they are detestable, disobedient, unfit for any good deed.

Responsorial. *Ep. 3, 8. 12; Rm. 1, 5*

R: To me, who am the least among the saints, has been conceded this grace of announcing to the Gentiles the infinite richness of Christ, * who gives us the courage of drawing near in complete faith to God through faith in him.

V: We have received the grace of the apostolate in order to obtain the obedience to the faith on the part of all the peoples, to the glory of his name.

R: who gives us the courage of drawing near in complete faith to God through faith in him.

Second Reading. *Book 2, 4*

The Shepherd should be discreet in keeping quiet and quick to speak.

A reading from the "Pastoral Rule" of St. Gregory the Great, pope.

The ruler should be discreet in keeping silence, profitable in speech; lest he either utter what ought to be suppressed or suppress what he ought to utter. For, as incautious speaking leads into error, so indiscreet silence leaves in error those who might have been instructed. For often improvident rulers, fearing to lose human favour, shrink timidly from speaking freely the things that are right; and, according to the voice of the Truth (John 10:12), serve unto the custody of the flock by no means with the zeal of shepherds, but in the way of hirelings; since they fly when the wolf comes if they hide themselves under silence. For hence it is that the Lord through the prophet upbraids them, saying, Dumb dogs, that cannot bark (Isaiah 56:10). Hence

again He complains, saying, You have not gone up against the enemy, neither opposed a wall for the house of Israel, to stand in the battle in the day of the Lord (Ezekiel 13:5). Now to go up against the enemy is to go with free voice against the powers of this world for defence of the flock; and to stand in the battle in the day of the Lord is out of love of justice to resist bad men when they contend against us. Then, for a shepherd to have feared to say what is right, what else is it but to have turned his back in keeping silence? But surely, if he puts himself in front for the flock, he opposes a wall against the enemy for the house of Israel. Hence again to the sinful people it is said, Your prophets have seen false and foolish things for you: neither did they uncover your iniquity, to provoke you to repentance (Lamentations 2:14). For in sacred language teachers are sometimes called prophets, in that, by pointing out how fleeting are present things, they make manifest the things that are to come. And such the divine discourse convinces of seeing false things, because, while fearing to reprove faults, they vainly flatter evil doers by promising security: neither do they at all uncover the iniquity of sinners, since they refrain their voice from chiding. For the language of reproof is the key of discovery, because by chiding it discloses the fault of which even he who has committed it is often himself unaware. Hence Paul says, That he may be able by sound doctrine even to convince the gainsayers (Titus 1: 9). And through Malachi; it is said. The priest's lips keep knowledge, and they shall seek the law at his mouth (Malachi 2:7). Hence through Isaiah the Lord admonishes, saying, Cry aloud, spare not, lift up your voice like a trumpet (Isaiah 58:1). For it is true that whosoever enters on the priesthood undertakes the office of a herald, so as to walk, himself crying aloud, before the coming of the judge who follows terribly. Wherefore, if the priest knows not how to preach, what voice of a loud cry shall the mute herald utter? For hence it is that the Holy Spirit sat upon the first pastors under the appearance of tongues (Acts 2:3); because whomsoever He has filled, He himself at once makes eloquent.

Responsorial. *Ps. 50, 15. 16 – 17*

R: I will teach wanderers your ways, and sinners will return to you; * my tongue will exalt your justice.

V: Lord, open my lips, and my mouth will proclaim your praise;

R: my tongue will exalt your justice.

YEAR A

Gospel. *Mt. 16: 13-23*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Now when Jesus came into the district of Caesare'a Philip'pi, he asked his disciples, "Who do men say that the Son of man is?" And they said, "Some say John the Baptist, others say Eli'jah, and others Jeremiah or one of the prophets." He said to them, "But who do you say that I am?" Simon Peter replied, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."

And Jesus answered him, "Blessed are you, Simon Bar-Jona! For flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but my Father who is in heaven. And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the powers of death shall not prevail against it. I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven, and whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven." Then he strictly charged the disciples to tell no one that he was the Christ.

From that time Jesus began to show his disciples that he must go to Jerusalem and suffer many things from the elders and chief priests and scribes, and be killed, and on the third day be raised. And Peter took him and began to rebuke him, saying, "God forbid, Lord! This shall never happen to you." But he turned and said to Peter, "Get behind me, Satan! You are a hindrance to me; for you are not on the side of God, but of men."

Third Reading. *Hom. 54: 1-6*

Christ handed over the keys to Peter

so that the Church could be diffused in the whole world.

A reading from the "Homilies on Matthew" of St. John Chrysostom, bishop.

"You are the Christ, the Son of the living God". "Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah, because neither flesh nor blood has revealed this to you" (Mt. 16: 17). Why is Peter proclaimed blessed? Because he has proclaimed true the Son of God. We cannot know the Son if not through the Father, nor the Father if not through the Son: and so the equality of the glory and the identity of the substance are demonstrated to us. What does Christ add? "You are Simon, the son of John: you will be called Cephas,

which means Peter” (Jn. 1: 42). Since you have exalted my Father, I remember the one who has generated you, which means: as you are the son of Jonah, so also I am the son of my Father.

It would have been useless in fact to say: “You are the son of John” (Jn. 1: 42); but since Peter had said “you are the Son of God”, Jesus added it in order to demonstrate that he was the Son of God in the same way that Peter was the Son of John, that is of the same substance of the Father.

“And I tell you: you are Peter and on this rock I will build my Church” (Mt. 16: 18), that is on the faith confessed by you. He declares in this way that many will believe one day, and elevating the sentiments of the apostle he constituted him the shepherd of his Church. “And the gates of the underworld will not prevail against it” (Mt. 16: 18). If they do not prevail against the Church, much less will they prevail against me. Do not worry therefore when you will see that I will be betrayed and put on the cross. Thus he confers on him another honour: “To you will I give the keys of the kingdom of heaven” (Mt. 16: 19). What does this mean: “To you I will give”? As the Father has let you know me I also will give you. He does not say: I will pray to the Father – even if this would have been a great demonstration of authority and a gift of ineffable value – but: I will give you. What? “The keys of the kingdom of heaven: and all that you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and all that you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven” (Mt. 16: 19).

Do you see how he lifts Peter up to considerations that are more sublime revealing himself and demonstrating with these two promises that he is the Son of God?

Jesus promises to give to Peter things that are due directly to God: to remit sins and to make the Church firm in the midst of much agitation of the waves, making a fisherman more secure than a rock, even if the entire world would be against him.

Thus the Father said speaking to the prophet Jeremiah, that he would place him as a column of iron and like a wall of bronze; with this difference: Jeremiah was put in front of only one nation, Peter instead in front of the whole world.

I would like to ask those who want to see the dignity of the Son diminished, if the gifts that the Father gives to Peter are greater than those that the Son makes to him. The Father reveals the Son; but he confers the mission of propagating throughout the world the knowledge of the Father

and of himself; and even more he gives to a mortal man every power in heaven, consigning the keys to him, he who has diffused the Church over all the earth and has manifested himself to be more steady than the heaven itself: in fact Jesus has said: "The heaven and the earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away" (Mt. 24: 35).

Responsorial. *Mt. 16: 17-18*

R: Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah, * because it is neither flesh nor blood which has revealed this to you, but my Father who is in heaven, says the Lord.

V: And I tell you: You are Peter and on this rock I will build my Church.

R: Because it is neither flesh nor blood which has revealed this to you, but my Father who is in heaven, says the Lord

YEAR B

Gospel. *Jn. 6: 60-69*

A reading from the Gospel of St. John.

Many of his disciples, when they heard it, said, "This is a hard saying; who can listen to it?" But Jesus, knowing in himself that his disciples murmured at it, said to them, "Do you take offence at this? Then what if you were to see the Son of man ascending where he was before? It is the spirit that gives life, the flesh is of no avail; the words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life. But there are some of you that do not believe." For Jesus knew from the first who those were that did not believe, and who it was that would betray him. And he said, "This is why I told you that no one can come to me unless it is granted him by the Father." After this many of his disciples drew back and no longer went about with him.

Jesus said to the twelve, "Do you also wish to go away?" Simon Peter answered him, "Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life; and we have believed, and have come to know, that you are the Holy One of God."

Third Reading. *Part II, 3*

The faith of the apostles.

A reading from the work “The Sacrament of the Altar” of Baldwin of Canterbury, bishop.

Among the disciples of Christ there were some who believed in him, others no; and among those who did not believe was Judas, who later would betray him. Christ knew them all, who were the believers and who were the non-believers; he even knew who would betray him and those who would go away from him. But before those who had decided to go away from him could do so, he showed that the faith in him does not belong to all, but to those to whom “it is granted by the Father” (Jn. 6: 65). Therefore neither flesh nor blood, but only the Father who is in heaven can reveal “the mystery of faith” (1 Tm. 3: 9); and he concedes this to some, to others no. He knows for what reason he does not give it, it is not for us to know it; and in front of the sight of such an incomprehensible and mysterious thing we cannot do anything else but exclaim full of wonder: “How rich are the depths of God – how deep his wisdom and knowledge- and how impossible to penetrate his judgements and how inaccessible his ways!” (Rm. 11: 33).

Many then among the disciples who did not believe turned back preferring to follow Satan and not Christ. Therefore Jesus said to the twelve who had remained: “Do you also want to go away? Simon Peter answered: Lord, to whom shall we go?” (Jn. 6: 67- 68). If we go away from you, where will we find life and truth, where the author of life, where a similar master of truth? “You have words of eternal life” (Jn. 6: 68). Your words, listened to with veneration and kept with deep faith, give eternal life. With your words you promise eternal life, offering us your body and your blood. And we, who believe in your words, “have believed and know that you are the Holy One of God” (Jn. 6: 69); that is that you yourself are eternal life, and in your flesh and in your blood you do not give anything else if not what you are. We have believed, he says, and known that you are the Son of God; therefore you have words of eternal life, and we believe and know that what you have said is true, that we must eat your flesh and drink your blood, because you are the Christ, the Son of God. He does not say: we have known and believed, but “we have believed and known”. From this we can understand that this knowledge is formed in the mind by the progressing of the faith. In fact it is written: “If you will not believe you will not have stability” (Is. 7: 9). The faith itself is in someway a knowledge even for those who believe with simplicity, without understanding its

reasoning. The knowledge instead that becomes formulated in concepts belongs to those who have the faculty that is exercised more in investigating the demonstrations of the faith, “ready always to answer to whoever asks a reason” (1 Pet. 3: 15) of the faith and of the hope that is in us.

Responsorial. *Act. 4: 12; 1 Cor. 3: 11*

R: In no one else is there salvation. * There is in fact no other name given to men by whom it is established that we can be saved.

V: For the foundation, nobody can lay any other than the one which has already been laid, that is Jesus Christ.

R: There is in fact no other name given to men by whom it is established that we can be saved.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 13: 22- 30*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

He went on his way through towns and villages, teaching, and journeying toward Jerusalem. And some one said to him, "Lord, will those who are saved be few?" And he said to them, "Strive to enter by the narrow door; for many, I tell you, will seek to enter and will not be able. When once the householder has risen up and shut the door, you will begin to stand outside and to knock at the door, saying, 'Lord, open to us.' He will answer you, 'I do not know where you come from.' Then you will begin to say, 'We ate and drank in your presence, and you taught in our streets.' But he will say, 'I tell you, I do not know where you come from; depart from me, all you workers of iniquity!' There you will weep and gnash your teeth, when you see Abraham and Isaac and Jacob and all the prophets in the kingdom of God and you yourselves thrust out. And men will come from east and west, and from north and south, and sit at table in the kingdom of God. And behold, some are last who will be first, and some are first who will be last."

Third Reading. *Lett. 112*

Love and you will have the kingdom: love and you will possess it.

A reading from the “Letters” of St, Anselm, bishop.

Dearest brothers, God proclaims that he has put on sale the kingdom of heaven; and this kingdom is so excellent that its beatitude and glory “eye has not seen, nor ear heard, nor has it ever entered into the heart of man” (1 Cor. 2: 9). But so that you can think of it in some way, know that whoever will deserve to reign up there, will find in heaven and on earth all that he wants; he instead who does not want, will not find it either in heaven or on earth. So great in fact will the love and the reciprocal union be between God and those who find themselves there that all of them will love the other as themselves; and nevertheless all will love God more than themselves. Therefore in heaven no one will want anything other than what God wants, and what one wants all will want; and that which one or all want together, God will want. Because whoever has a desire will see it realised be it with regard to himself and with regard to the others and to every creature, as also with regard to God. And so the individuals will be perfect sovereigns because all that they want will be carried out; and all together with God will be only one king and as only one man, because all will want only one thing and that which they want will be realised.

From heaven God proclaims that all this is on sale.

If someone asks at what price, he is answered: he who wants to give the kingdom of heaven does not need an earthly payment, nor can anyone give to God what he does not possess, because all that exist belongs to him. On the other hand God does not give a thing of such value completely gratuitously, because he does not give it to the one who does not love him. No one in fact gives that which is dearest to him to the one who does not love him. God therefore does not need something that is yours, nor does he have to give such a great thing to the one who does not care to love him: he searches for love, without which he is not obliged to give anything. Give him therefore love and you will obtain the kingdom: love and you will have it.

Finally, since to reign in heaven is no other than to be only one thing with God and with all the saints, the angels and men, united in only one will through the love so much as to exercise all together only one power: love God more than yourself and you will already begin to have on the earth that which you want to have perfectly in heaven. Be of only one will with God and with men, with those only however who are not in conflict with God,

and you will begin in this way to reign with God and with all the just men. In the measure in which you now conform yourself to the will of God and of men, God and all his saints will conform themselves to your will. If therefore you want to be sovereign in heaven, love God and men as you need to and you will deserve to be that which you desire.

But you will not be able to have this perfect love, if you will not have emptied your heart of every other type of love. Therefore those who have their hearts full of the love of God and of the neighbour, do not want anything else if not that which God wants, or any other thing as long as it is not against God. For this they apply themselves assiduously in prayer and in talks and meditations on the heavenly realities, because it is sweet for them to desire God, to speak to him and to hear him speak, and to think of him whom they love so much; therefore they are glad with the one who is glad, they cry with the one who cries, they have compassion on the miserable and help the poor; thus they love the others as themselves. They despise riches, the first places, pleasures, and they do not love being praised and honoured, because he who loves these things, often fails against God and against the neighbour.

“On these two commandments depends all the Law and the Prophets” (Mt. 22: 40). He therefore who wants to have that perfect love with which the kingdom of heaven is acquired, must love contempt, poverty, trials and submission, as the holy men do.

Responsorial. *Act. 4: 12; 1 Cor. 3: 11*

R: In no other is there salvation; * There is no other name in fact given to men under the heavens, in which it has been established that we can be saved.

V: No one can put a foundation that is different from that which is already to be found, that is Jesus Christ.

R: There is no other name in fact given to men under the heavens, in which it has been established that we can be saved.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 4:25 – 5:7*

Be imitators of God.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

Therefore, putting away falsehood, let every one speak the truth with his neighbour, for we are members one of another. Be angry but do not sin; do not let the sun go down on your anger, and give no opportunity to the devil. Let the thief no longer steal, but rather let him labour, doing honest work with his hands, so that he may be able to give to those in need. Let no evil talk come out of your mouths, but only such as is good for edifying, as fits the occasion, that it may impart grace to those who hear. And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, in whom you were sealed for the day of redemption. Let all bitterness and wrath and anger and clamour and slander be put away from you, with all malice, and be kind to one another, tender hearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ forgave you.

Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children. And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God. But fornication and all impurity or covetousness must not even be named among you, as is fitting among saints. Let there be no filthiness, nor silly talk, nor levity, which are not fitting; but instead let there be thanksgiving. Be sure of this, that no fornicator or impure man, or one who is covetous (that is, an idolater), has any inheritance in the kingdom of Christ and of God. Let no one deceive you with empty words, for it is because of these things that the wrath of God comes upon the sons of disobedience. Therefore do not associate with them.

Responsorial. *Col. 4, 2 – 3; Philemon 4, 6*

R: Persevere in prayer and keep vigil in it, giving thanks. Pray also for us, * so that God may open the doors of the preaching and we may be able to announce the mystery of Christ.

V: In every necessity place before God your requests.

R: so that God may open the doors of the preaching and we may be able to announce the mystery of Christ.

Second Reading. *Disc. 5,5*

The charity and the school of Christ.

A reading from the “Discourses” of the blessed Oglerio, abbot

We, brothers, who from Christ take the name of Christians and so we are, despise all transitory and fallen goods with their blind adorers and desiring to adhere to him alone, unite ourselves in brotherly fraternity in order to merit being called, and being really disciples of him who to his apostles, and to us through them, has given this command: “By this all will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another” (Jn. 13, 35).

From this the sons of the light are distinguished from the sons of darkness, the disciples of Christ from the disciples of the evil one, if they dilate reciprocally and towards all charity. Charity does not exclude anyone, but embraces everyone and contains everyone giving itself to everyone without distinction.

Charity is the affection of the heart that clasps Christ in the embrace of love. Charity is love that holds heaven and earth tightly; it is an invincible love, which does not fail even in front of threats and pleas. Charity is the indissoluble bond of love and peace; charity, queen of virtue, does not fear the arrival of any vice, but having received in pledge the blood of Christ and bearing on the front the vessel of the cross, turns to flight all its adversaries; and no one can resist its strength.

It is the friend of the eternal King, for which it is not afraid to draw near to him in complete trust. If among us, brothers, this queen of virtue reigns, immediately everyone, great and small, will know that we are truly disciples of the Lord. He who does not love does not belong to him who has given the commandment of love. Charity is the love of God and of the neighbour: he who does not love his neighbour cannot love God either and he who does not love, hates. Therefore he who hates his own brother, hates the author of charity. We therefore, gathered together by the love of Christ, love the Lord with all the heart and with all the soul, and the neighbour as our self; and, for love of him, we love not only the friends, but also the enemies, not being content with ourselves for not hating them, but having a

true love for them. This is the school of Christ, this is the doctrine of the Holy Spirit. He, who goes away from this school and does not persevere in this doctrine, will perish in eternity. To the disciples of Jesus Christ, instead, to the lovers of charity, will be given the immense sweetness, the riches and the joy of eternal beatitudes, that he, who lives and reigns in the womb of the perfect Trinity will deign to give to us, God, blessed forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Rm. 13, 8. 10; Gal. 5, 14*

R: Do not have any debt with anyone, if not that of reciprocal love; because he who loves his fellow man has fulfilled the law. * Complete fulfilment of the law is love.

V: All the law finds its fullness in only one precept: to love your neighbour as yourself.

R: Complete fulfilment of the law is love.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Titus 2: 1 – 3:2*

Exhortation to the faithful.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Titus.

But as for you, teach what befits sound doctrine. Bid the older men be temperate, serious, sensible, sound in faith, in love, and in steadfastness.

Bid the older women likewise to be reverent in behaviour, not to be slanderers or slaves to drink; they are to teach what is good, and so train the young women to love their husbands and children, to be sensible, chaste, domestic, kind, and submissive to their husbands, that the word of God may not be discredited. Likewise urge the younger men to control themselves. Show yourself in all respects a model of good deeds, and in your teaching show integrity, gravity, and sound speech that cannot be censured, so that an opponent may be put to shame, having nothing evil to say of us. Bid slaves to be submissive to their masters and to give satisfaction in every respect; they are not to be refractory, nor to pilfer, but to show entire and true fidelity, so that in everything they may adorn the doctrine of God our Saviour.

For the grace of God has appeared for the salvation of all men, training us to renounce irreligion and worldly passions, and to live sober, upright, and godly lives in this world, awaiting our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ, who gave himself for us to redeem us from all iniquity and to purify for himself a people of his own who are zealous for good deeds. Declare these things; exhort and reprove with all authority. Let no one disregard you.

Remind them to be submissive to rulers and authorities, to be obedient, to be ready for any honest work, to speak evil of no one, to avoid quarrelling, to be gentle, and to show perfect courtesy toward all men.

Responsorial. *cfr. Tit. 2, 12. 13; Ep. 5, 15 – 16*

R: Repudiating wickedness and worldly desires, let us live with soberness, justice and mercy in this world, * waiting for the manifestation of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ.

V: Let us keep vigil attentively on our conduct: behaving not like fools, but like wise men, making profit of this present time.

R: waiting for the manifestation of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ.

Second Reading. *Book 1, 9. 34. 38 – 39*

There is need to pray in a special way for the whole body of the Church.

A reading from the treatise “Cain and Abel” of St. Ambrose, bishop.

“Offer a sacrifice of praise and pay your vows to the Most High.” To praise God means to make your vow and fulfil it. That is why the Samaritan who was cured of leprosy at Jesus command together with his nine companions is preferred to the others, because he was the only one to return to Christ, praising God and giving thanks. Jesus said to him: “Was there none of them to come back and give thanks except this foreigner?”

And he told him: “Rise and go on your way: your faith has made you whole.”

The Lord Jesus also taught you in his own wonderful way about the goodness of the Father, who knows how to give good things, so that you should ask for good things from the one who is goodness itself. He told us to pray urgently and frequently: not that our prayers should be tedious and

endless but that they should be persevering and frequent. Generally speaking, long prayers are full of meaningless phrases, while on the other hand total lack of interest is the result if prayers are given up altogether.

Next he warns that when you ask pardon for yourself it is then above all that you should remember to grant it to others, so that your prayer will be reinforced by your good works. The apostle also teaches that when you pray you should not be angry or involved in a quarrel with anyone, so that your prayer will not be unsettled or spoilt. He also teaches us to pray everywhere, while our Saviour says: "Go into your room."

You must not think that he means by this a room with four walls separating you physically from others, but the room that is within you, where your thoughts are shut up, the place that contains your feelings. This room of prayer is with you at all times, wherever you go it is a secret place and what happens there is witnessed by God alone.

But you are taught to pray above all for the people, that is for the whole body, for all the members of your holy mother the Church, whose distinguishing mark is brotherly love. If you ask for something for yourself, you will be praying only for yourself. And if everyone prays only for himself, then you must remember that the favour shown to a sinner is less than that granted to someone asking on behalf of another. But now, because each is praying for all, then all are praying for everyone.

We can sum up in this way: if you ask for something only for yourself, you will be asking for yourself, as we have said, on your own.

But if you ask for everybody, then everybody will be asking for you. For you are in fact in all. The reward then, is great, for the support of the whole people is gained for each individual by the prayers of each individual.

There is no presumption in this point of view, only a sign of greater humility and the prospect of richer benefits.

Responsorial: *Ps. 60, 2 – 3. 6*

R: Listen to my cry, O God, be attentive to my prayer: * from the ends of the earth I invoke you.

V: You, O God, have listened to my vows, you have given me the inheritance of the one who fears your name:

R: from the ends of the earth I invoke you.

Gospel. Mt. 23: 13 – 22

Woe to you, blind guides.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"But woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! Because you shut the kingdom of heaven against men; for you neither enter yourselves, nor allow those who would enter to go in.

Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you traverse sea and land to make a single proselyte, and when he becomes a proselyte, you make him twice as much a child of hell as yourselves.

"Woe to you, blind guides, who say, 'If any one swears by the temple, it is nothing; but if any one swears by the gold of the temple, he is bound by his oath.' You blind fools! For which is greater, the gold or the temple that has made the gold sacred? And you say, 'If any one swears by the altar, it is nothing; but if any one swears by the gift that is on the altar, he is bound by his oath.'

You blind men! For which is greater, the gift or the altar that makes the gift sacred? So he, who swears by the altar, swears by it and by everything on it; and he, who swears by the temple, swears by it and by him who dwells in it; and he who swears by heaven, swears by the throne of God and by him who sits upon it.

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 5:8 – 21*

Walk like sons of light.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

For once you were darkness, but now you are light in the Lord; walk as children of light (for the fruit of light is found in all that is good and right and true), and try to learn what is pleasing to the Lord. Take no part in the unfruitful works of darkness, but instead expose them. For it is a shame even to speak of the things that they do in secret; but when anything is exposed by the light it becomes visible, for anything that becomes visible is light. Therefore it is said, "Awake, O sleeper, and arise from the dead, and Christ shall give you light." Look carefully then how you walk, not as unwise men but as wise, making the most of the time, because the days are evil. Therefore do not be foolish, but understand what the will of the Lord is. And do not get drunk with wine, for that is debauchery; but be filled with the Spirit, addressing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody to the Lord with all your heart, always and for everything giving thanks in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ to God the Father. Be subject to one another out of reverence for Christ.

Responsorial. *Ep. 5, 8 – 9; Mt. 5, 14. 16*

R: You are light in the Lord: behave like children of the light. * The fruit of light consists in every goodness, justice and truth.

V: You are the light of the world. Let your light shine out in front of men.

R: The fruit of light consists in every goodness, justice and truth.

Second Reading. *Nm. 13 – 14*

When you sing psalms, everyone has to sing psalms.

A reading from the treatise “The good of singing psalms” of Niceta of Reims, bishop.

My dearest, let us psalmodize with an intent soul and a vigilant mind, as the psalmist exhorts us saying: “God is king of all the earth, sing hymns

with art” (Ps. 46, 8); in a way that the psalm is recited not only with the “spirit”, that is with the sound of the voice, but also with the “mind” (cfr.1Cor.14, 15) meditating interiorly that which we psalmodize, so that the mind, dominated by strange thoughts, may not have to toil without fruit. Everything has to be celebrated while being in the presence of God, and not with the worry of pleasing men or oneself. We have an example of this consonance of the voice in those three most blessed young boys of which the book of Daniel speaks, when it says: “ Then those three young men, with only one voice, started to praise, to glorify, to bless God in the furnace saying: Blessed are you, Lord, God of our fathers (Dn. 3, 51 – 52).

Do you see how we are taught that the three praised the Lord with only one voice, so that we also can express with unanimity the same hearing with the same modulation of the voice. For this when we sing the psalms, every one has to psalmodize; when one prays, all have to pray, when the reading is proclaimed, keep silence, all together listen to it, and let it not happen that while the lector proclaims the reading another disturbs by praying in a loud voice. If then you have to arrive during the reading, having fulfilled the adoration to God and the sign of the cross, dispose yourself with care to listening.

The time of prayer is given to you when everyone prays, and it is given to you again every time that you want to pray privately: however in order to pray do not lose the reading, because you cannot have this always at your disposition and in the way that you want it, while the possibility of praying is always within your reach. And do not believe that it is of little use to listen to the sacred readings: in fact the same prayer is enriched, because the mind, nourished by the divine reality that is listened to, proceeds with greater facility.

In fact Mary, who leaves her sister Martha, while she remains seated at the feet of Jesus listened more attentively to the word, “she has chosen the better part” (cfr.Lk.10, 39.42), as the Lord confirmed. Therefore the deacon proclaims in a clear voice admonishing every one because in the prayer, in the prostration, in the psalmody, as in the listening of the sacred reading, the unity is conserved; the Lord loves in fact those who are unanimous, and he makes them live in his house (cfr.Ps.67, 7).

Responsorial. *Ps. 137, 1 – 2; 117, 28*

R: Before the angels I want to sing to you, I prostrate myself before your holy temple. * I give thanks to your name, Lord.

V: You are my God and I give you thanks, you are my God and I exalt you.

R: I give thanks to your name, Lord.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Titus 3: 3 – 15*

The bath of regeneration.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Titus.

For we ourselves were once foolish, disobedient, led astray, slaves to various passions and pleasures, passing our days in malice and envy, hated by men and hating one another; but when the goodness and loving kindness of God our Saviour appeared, he saved us, not because of deeds done by us in righteousness, but in virtue of his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal in the Holy Spirit, which he poured out upon us richly through Jesus Christ our Saviour, He did this so that we might be justified by his grace and become heirs in hope of eternal life. The saying is sure. I desire you to insist on these things, so that those who have believed in God may be careful to apply themselves to good deeds; these are excellent and profitable to men.

But avoid stupid controversies, genealogies, dissensions, and quarrels over the law, for they are unprofitable and futile. As for a man who is factious, after admonishing him once or twice, have nothing more to do with him, knowing that such a person is perverted and sinful; he is self-condemned.

When I send Artemas or Tych'icus to you, do your best to come to me at Nicop'olis, for I have decided to spend the winter there. Do your best to speed Zenas the lawyer and Apol'los on their way; see that they lack nothing. And let our people learn to apply themselves to good deeds, so as to help cases of urgent need, and not to be unfruitful. All who are with me send greetings to you. Greet those who love us in the faith. Grace be with you all.

Responsorial. *Ps. 102, 13 – 14; Tit. 3, 5*

R: As a father has mercy on his sons, so the Lord has mercy on those who fear him. * Because he knows of what we have been formed.

V: He has saved us not in virtue of the works that we have accomplished, but because of his mercy.

R: Because he knows of what we have been formed.

Second Reading. *Disc. 4: 2 – 7*

No one must despair because of the greatness of his sins.

A reading from the Discourse of the IXth century.

Brothers, you have often heard spoken of two men, Adam and Christ: the first is the old, the second is new. Therefore he who is old is wicked, because he imitates the one who in paradise was proud and disobedient. He who is good is new, because he follows the one who said: “Learn from me for I am meek and humble of heart” (Mt. 11, 29) and of whom the Apostle affirms that he made himself “obedient unto death” (Phil. 2, 8).

Now because our time is called new, we exhort those who are old and live badly, to become new by converting to good. We incite those who are already new because of their good works, to try to renew themselves in this new time with better works. He who, for example is new because of chastity, having cast away vices, should renew himself renouncing also to the desire of evil.

So also he who is humble, obedient, merciful and patient, must renew himself, praying and everyday making progress in those virtues, according to what is written: They will go from virtue to virtue (Ps. 83, 8).

None of you, my dearest, is secure only because of the fact that he has been baptised: As not all those who run in the stadium win the prize (cfr. 1Cor. 9, 24), but only he who arrives first, so also not all those who have faith will save themselves, but only those who persevere in the good work that has been initiated. And as every combatant “is temperate in everything” (1Cor. 9, 25), so also you have to abstain from all the vices in order to defeat the devil, your persecutor. By means of the faith you have been called by the Lord in his vineyard, that is in the unity of the Holy Church: live and behave in a way that you can receive the money, that is the beatitude of the kingdom freely given by God.

No one must despair because of the greatness of his sins, saying: My sins are many, in which I have persevered up to old age and up to decay; in

a way that I cannot obtain forgiveness, in so much as it has been they who have abandoned me and not I who have left them. May it not be that he despairs of the mercy of God, because some have been called in the vineyard of the Lord during the first hour, others at the third, others yet again at the sixth; others then at the ninth and in the end others at the eleventh hour. That is, some have been attracted to the service of God right from their infancy, others during adolescence, others during their youth, others during their old age and finally others in the time of decay.

And as no one, in whatever age he finds himself, should despair of being able to convert, so also no one must feel himself secure only because of the fact of having faith, but above all he must fear what has been written: "Many are called, but few are elected" (Mt. 22, 14). We know that we have been called through faith, but we do not know if we are elected. Therefore every one should be all the more humble, in so much as we do not know if we have been elected or not.

May the almighty God concede that you are not among the number of those who pass the Red Sea with dry feet, who eat the manna in the desert and who quench their thirst of the spiritual drink and then die in that same desert because of their grumbling; but that you may be numbered among those who enter into the promised land and, working faithfully in the vineyard of the Church, are found worthy of receiving the denarius of the eternal beatitudes; in a way that you can, together with Christ your head, of whom you are members, reign for all eternity. Amen.

Responsorial. *cfr. Vulg. Est. 14, 3. 19; Tob. 3, 13; Jdt. 6, 15*

R: Besides you I have no other hope O Lord, God of Israel. * You, who even in anger use mercy, and in the time of tribulation forgive sins.

V: Lord, God of heaven and earth, look at our humiliation.

R: You, who even in anger use mercy, and in the time of tribulation forgive sins.

Gospel. *Mt. 23: 23 – 26*

These things you need to practise, without omitting the others.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you tithe mint and dill and cummin, and have neglected the weightier matters of the law, justice and mercy and faith; these you ought to have done, without

neglecting the others. You blind guides, straining out a gnat and swallowing a camel!

"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you cleanse the outside of the cup and of the plate, but inside they are full of extortion and rapacity. You blind Pharisee! **First cleanse the inside of the cup and of the plate**, that the **outside also may be clean**.

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 5: 22 – 33*

Duties of the couples.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul , apostle, to the Ephesians.

Wives, be subject to your husbands, as to the Lord. For the husband is the head of the wife as Christ is the head of the church, his body, and is himself its Saviour. As the church is subject to Christ, so let wives also be subject in everything to their husbands. Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her, that he might sanctify her, having cleansed her by the washing of water with the word, that he might present the church to himself in splendour, without spot or wrinkle or any such thing, that she might be holy and without blemish. Even so husbands should love their wives as their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. For no man ever hates his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, as Christ does the church, because we are members of his body. "For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother and be joined to his wife, and the two shall become one flesh." This mystery is a profound one, and I am saying that it refers to Christ and the church; however, let each one of you love his wife as himself, and let the wife see that she respects her husband.

Responsorial. *Gn. 2, 23. 24; Ep. 5, 32*

R: This is flesh of my flesh and bone of my bones. For this the man will abandon his father and his mother and he will unite himself to his wife; * and the two will become only one flesh.

V: This is a great mystery: I say this in reference to Christ and to the Church.

R: and the two will become only one flesh.

Second Reading. *Hom. 3: 3*

This mystery is great.

A reading from the “Homilies on some passages of the New Testament” of St. John Chrysostom, bishop.

As Eve came out of the side of Adam, so also we have come out of the side of Christ. This is what the expression “flesh of my flesh and bone of my bones” (Gn. 2, 23) wants to say. Everyone knows that Eve was formed from the side of Adam, and in the Scriptures it is clearly read that God made a deep sleep come upon him, he took out a rib and with it formed the woman. From where therefore can we apprehend that the Church has been born from the side of Christ? It is the Scriptures again that reveals this to us.

After Christ, lifted up and nailed on the cross, gave up his spirit, “one of the soldiers struck his side with a lance and immediately there came out blood and water” (Jn. 19, 34): of that water and of that blood the whole Church is born. He Himself testifies to this saying: “If anyone is not born from water and the Holy Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God” (Jn. 3, 5); and here he calls Spirit the blood. In reality we come to the light thanks to the water of baptism, and we are then kept in life by the blood. Do you see therefore in what way we are flesh of his flesh and bone of his bone, from the moment that from that blood and from that water we are generated and kept in life?

As the woman was formed while Adam was immersed in a deep sleep, so also the Church was born from the side of Christ immersed in death. Above all the woman must not be loved only because of the fact that she is a member of our body and derives her origin from us, but still more because God has given him this explicit command saying: “For this the man will abandon his father and his mother, and will unite himself to his wife and the two will become only one flesh” (Jn. 2, 24). Paul also reminds us of this law in order to lead us in all ways to that love. Consider now with me the wisdom of the Apostle: not with only human or divine laws does he induce us to love the wives, but with the one and the other together; in a way that the men who are more elevated and spiritual may be greatly solicited by the divine laws; those instead who are weaker and simple, may draw incitement to love from the natural laws. Therefore he first expounds this doctrine starting from the example of Christ saying: “Love your wives, as Christ has loved the Church” (Ep. 5, 25); in a second moment he adds the human motivations: “Husbands have the duty to love the wives as their own bodies” then he refers to Christ again: “Because we are members of his body” (Ep. 5, 28. 30), flesh of his flesh and bone of his bones; then he returns yet again to the human argument: “For this a man will leave his

father and his mother and will unite himself to his woman” (Ep. 5, 31); and after having reaffirmed this law he exclaims: “This mystery is great” (Ep. 5, 32).

Tell me: why is it great? Because it regards Christ and his Church. As the bridegroom, having left the father, hurries to meet the bride, so also Christ, having abandoned the paternal house, moves towards his bride: he has not called us to the sublime highness of the heavens, but he himself has descended to us. When we then hear of his coming being spoken of, we do not think of a movement, but rather of his adaptation: in fact, though being with us, he remained with the Father. For this the Apostle says: “This mystery is great” (Ep. 5, 32). Great also with regard to men; but above all when you consider it with reference to Christ and to his Church, then really the greatness of the mystery fills me with amazement. For this after having said: “This mystery is great” he immediately adds: “I say this of Christ and of the Church” (Ep. 5, 32).

Responsorial. *cfr. Ap. 21, 10. 12. 14. 2*

R: I saw the door of the city facing the East and the names of the apostles of the Lamb written on it, * and on its walls the angels kept vigil.

V: I saw the holy city, the new Jerusalem, come down from heaven, as beautiful as a bride all dressed for her husband,

R: and on its walls the angels kept vigil.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *1 Tm. 1: 1 – 20*

The mission of Timothy. Paul minister of the gospel.

A reading from the first Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Timothy.

Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by command of God our Saviour and of Christ Jesus our hope, To Timothy, my true child in the faith: Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

As I urged you when I was going to Macedonia, remain at Ephesus that you may charge certain persons not to teach any different doctrine, nor to occupy themselves with myths and endless genealogies which promote speculations rather than the divine training that is in faith; whereas the aim of our charge is love that issues from a pure heart and a good conscience

and sincere faith. Certain persons by swerving from these have wandered away into vain discussion, desiring to be teachers of the law, without understanding either what they are saying or the things about which they make assertions.

Now we know that the law is good, if any one uses it lawfully, understanding this, that the law is not laid down for the just but for the lawless and disobedient, for the ungodly and sinners, for the unholy and profane, for murderers of fathers and murderers of mothers, for man-slayers, immoral persons, sodomites, kidnappers, liars, perjurers, and whatever else is contrary to sound doctrine, in accordance with the glorious gospel of the blessed God with which I have been entrusted.

I thank him who has given me strength for this, Christ Jesus our Lord, because he judged me faithful by appointing me to his service, though I formerly blasphemed and persecuted and insulted him; but I received mercy because I had acted ignorantly in unbelief, and the grace of our Lord overflowed for me with the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus. The saying is sure and worthy of full acceptance, that Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners. And I am the foremost of sinners; but I received mercy for this reason, that in me, as the foremost, Jesus Christ might display his perfect patience for an example to those who were to believe in him for eternal life. To the King of ages, immortal, invisible, the only God, be honour and glory forever and ever. Amen.

This charge I commit to you, Timothy, my son, in accordance with the prophetic utterances which pointed to you, that inspired by them you may wage the good warfare, holding faith and a good conscience. By rejecting conscience, certain persons have made shipwreck of their faith, among them Hymenae'us and Alexander, whom I have delivered to Satan that they may learn not to blaspheme.

Responsorial. *1 Tm. 1, 14. 15; Rm. 3, 23*

R: The grace of our Lord has over abounded, together with faith and charity. * Christ Jesus has come into the world to save the sinners.

V: All have sinned and are without the glory of God.

R: Christ Jesus has come into the world to save the sinners.

Second Reading. *Lett. 161 : 1 – 2*

Act energetically like an expert pilot.

A reading from the “Letter to bishop Amphilochius” of St. Basil the Great, bishop.

Blessed be God Who from age to age chooses them that please Him, distinguishes vessels of election, and uses them for the ministry of the Saints. Though you were trying to flee, as you confess, not from me, but from the calling you expected through me, He has netted you in the sure meshes of grace, and has brought you into the midst of Pisidia to catch men for the Lord, and draw the devil’s prey from the deep into the light. You too, may say as the blessed David said, “Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence.” Such is the wonderful work of our loving Master. “Asses are lost” that there may be a king of Israel. David, however, being an Israelite was granted to Israel; but the land which has nursed you and brought you to such a height of virtue, possesses you no longer, and sees her neighbour beautified by her own adornment. But all believers in Christ are one people; all Christ’s people, although He is hailed from many regions, are one Church; and so our country is glad and rejoices at the dispensation of the Lord, and instead of thinking that she is one man the poorer, considers that through one man she has become possessed of whole Churches. Only may the Lord grant me both to see you in person, and, so long as I am parted from you, to hear of your progress in the gospel, and of the good order of your Churches.

Play the man, then, and be strong, and walk before the people whom the Most High has entrusted to your hand. Like a skilful pilot, rise in mind above every wave lifted by heretical blasts; keep the boat from being overwhelmed by the salt and bitter billows of false doctrine; and wait for the calm to be made by the Lord as soon as there shall have been found a voice worthy of rousing Him to rebuke the winds and the sea. If you wish to visit me, now hurried by long sickness towards the inevitable end, do not wait for an opportunity, or for the word from me. You know that to a father’s heart every time is suitable to embrace a well-loved son, and that affection is stronger than words. Do not lament over a responsibility transcending your strength. If you had been destined to bear the burden unaided, it would have been not merely heavy; it would have been intolerable. But if the Lord shares the load with you, “cast all your care upon the Lord” and He will Himself act. Only be exhorted ever to give heed lest you be carried away by wicked customs. Rather change all previous

evil ways into good by the help of the wisdom given you by God. For Christ has sent you not to follow others, but yourself to take the lead of all who are being saved. I charge you to pray for me, that, if I am still in this life, I may be permitted to see you with your Church. If, however, it is ordained that I now depart, may I see all of you hereafter with the Lord, your Church blooming like a vine with good works, and yourself like a wise husbandman and good servant giving meat in due season to his fellow-servants and receiving the reward of a wise and trusty steward. All who are with me salute your reverence. May you be strong and joyful in the Lord. May you be preserved glorious in the graces of the Spirit and of wisdom.

Responsorial. *Ep. 6, 10 – 11; cfr. Jb. 7, 1*

R: Draw strength from the Lord and from the vigour of his power. * Clothe yourselves with the armour of God, in order to resist the traps of the devil.

V: Because the life of man on this earth is a hard battle.

R: Clothe yourselves with the armour of God, in order to resist the traps of the devil.

Gospel. *Mt. 23: 27 – 32*

You are children of those who killed the prophets.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you are like whitewashed tombs, which outwardly appear beautiful, but within they are full of dead men's bones and all uncleanness. So you also outwardly appear righteous to men, but within you are full of hypocrisy and iniquity.

"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you build the tombs of the prophets and adorn the monuments of the righteous, saying, 'If we had lived in the days of our fathers, we would not have taken part with them in shedding the blood of the prophets.' Thus you witness against yourselves, that you are sons of those who murdered the prophets. Fill up, then, the measure of your fathers.

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 6: 1 – 9*

Duties in domestic life.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right. "Honour your father and mother" (this is the first commandment with a promise), "that it may be well with you and that you may live long on the earth." Fathers, do not provoke your children to anger, but bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord.

Slaves, be obedient to those who are your earthly masters, with fear and trembling, in singleness of heart, as to Christ; not in the way of eye-service, as men-pleasers, but as servants of Christ, doing the will of God from the heart, rendering service with a good will as to the Lord and not to men, knowing that whatever good any one does, he will receive the same again from the Lord, whether he is a slave or free. Masters, do the same to them, and forbear threatening, knowing that he who is both their Master and yours is in heaven, and that there is no partiality with him.

Responsorial. *cfr. 1 Cor. 7, 22 – 23; Gal. 3, 28*

R: The slave who has been called in the Lord, is a freed man liberated by the Lord, he who is called as a free man, is a slave of Christ. * You have been bought at a dear price, don't make yourselves slaves of men.

V: In Christ Jesus there is no Jew or Greek, there is no more slave or free man.

R: You have been bought at a dear price, don't make yourselves slaves of men.

Second Reading. *Book 2, Hom. 1, 7*

The hope of heavenly prizes.

A reading from the “Homilies on the prophet Ezekiel” of St. Gregory the Great, pope.

Only he who in the holy Church meditates on the ways of the just in order to imitate them can be introduced into the heavenly city. To be introduced consists in considering the house placed on the top of the mountain that is like the elect of the holy Church, who have reached the summit of virtue, who progress loving. One in fact who conducts a matrimonial life, is content with that which he possesses, and does not appropriate himself of the riches of the others, he gives his surplus to the needy, does not stop crying over the sins that ordinarily he commits in daily life. The same preoccupation of the family then is for him a motive of worry and pushes him to tears.

Another instead has already abandoned all the goods of the world, not desiring anything for himself, nourishes himself only through contemplation, cries with happiness in the hope of heavenly rewards, deprives himself also of that which would be conceded to him to possess everyday, and is eager for the encounter with God in the silence of loneliness, no preoccupation of this world that passes worries his soul, which instead day by day expands in the expectation of the joys of heaven.

Another again has abandoned all the goods of this world in order to turn internally his heart to the contemplation of the heavenly realities; above all, having to occupy a place of command for the edification of the brothers, though not giving in to the desires of the fallen realities, he is forced to occupy himself with them sometimes moved by the compassion for his neighbour, in order to come in this way to the help of all those who are in need; to those who listen he announces the word of life, and administers the necessary for both the soul and the bodies. And it is he who, for himself, in contemplation lives already eager for the desires of heaven, yet for the utility and the good of the neighbour accepts to occupy himself with the labours of the temporal realities.

For this reason he who in the holy Church employs himself with solicitude to progress, either in the holiness of conjugal life, or in the asceticism of the virgins and of those who abandon all the goods of this world, or in the perfection of the preachers, have already entered and already live in the city placed on the mountain. He instead who stops looking for a better life in order to progress, finds himself still outside that house. And

even though he may admire the honour of which the holy Church already enjoys in the world, yet he is like one who looks at a building only from the outside and marvels. And because he places his attention only on the outside, he has not yet entered inside.

Responsorial. *Rm. 8, 23; 1 Chr. 29, 15*

R: We who possess the first fruits of the Spirit; * cry inwardly awaiting the adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies.

V: We are foreigners in front of you and pilgrims like all our fathers;

R: we cry inwardly awaiting the adoption as sons, the redemption of our bodies.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *1 Tm. 2: 1 – 15*

Exhortation to prayer.

A reading from the first Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Timothy.

First of all, then, I urge that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings be made for all men, for kings and all who are in high positions, that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life, godly and respectful in every way. This is good, and it is acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour, who desires all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all, the testimony to which was borne at the proper time. For this I was appointed a preacher and apostle (I am telling the truth, I am not lying), a teacher of the Gentiles in faith and truth. I desire then that in every place the men should pray, lifting holy hands without anger or quarrelling;

Also that women should adorn themselves modestly and sensibly in seemly apparel, not with braided hair or gold or pearls or costly attire but by good deeds, as befits women who profess religion. Let a woman learn in silence with all submissiveness. I permit no woman to teach or to have authority over men; she is to keep silent. For Adam was formed first, then Eve; and Adam was not deceived, but the woman was deceived and became

a transgressor. Yet woman will be saved through bearing children, if she continues in faith and love and holiness, with modesty.

Responsorial. *1 Tm. 2, 5 – 6; Heb. 2, 17*

R: One only is God, one only the mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus; * He has given himself as a ransom for all.

V: He had to make himself similar in everything to the brothers, in order to become merciful:

R: he has given himself as a ransom for all.

Second Reading. *Hom 6: 1 – 2*

Each one of our prayers contains a thanksgiving.

A reading from the “Homilies on the first letter to Timothy” of St. John Chrysostom, bishop.

The priest is like a universal father. He needs therefore to take care of everyone, like God of whom he is priest; for this Paul says: “I recommend you first of all that he makes prayers and intercessions” (1 Tm. 2,1). From this are derived two good things: the hate that we have against the others is dissolved, because no one can hate the one for whom he prays; and they themselves become better, both because they pray for them, and because the scope of that prayer is that it puts aside their resentment against us. Nothing in fact helps teaching so much as loving and being loved.

Think what a great thing it would be that those who lay down traps, who scourge, who beat, who kill, could know that the victims of this violence offer ardent prayers to God for those who commit these acts against them!

Do you not see how the Apostle wants that the Christian is superior to all? As it happens that with children that, even if the small baby who is carried in the arms hits the face of his father, the paternal affection truly does not diminish because of this, so also us, even if we are beaten by those others, we must not be unkind to them.

What does this mean? “First of all” (1 Tm. 2, 1). It means: in the daily cult. And those who are being initiated know that every day we pray, morning and evening, and that we raise up intercessions for the entire world, for the kings and men of government.

Look at what he says and how, to render acceptable the exhortation, he adds the advantage that follows it: “So that we can pass, he says, a calm and peaceful life” (1 Tm. 2, 2). In other words, from the well being of these comes our peace: so also in the letter to the Romans, exhorting the faithful to obey the civil authorities, he says: “Not only because of fear of punishment, but also for reasons of conscience” (Rm. 13, 5). “Petitions, he says, intercessions, prayers and thanksgivings” (1Tm. 2, 1). Yes, certainly, we need to thank God also for the goods conceded to the others: for example; because “he makes his sun rise on the wicked and on the good and he makes the rain fall on the just and on the unjust” (Mt. 5, 45). Do you see how he unites us and holds us together, not only with the prayer, but also with the thanksgiving? In fact that which forces us to give thanks to God for the goods of our neighbour, pushes us to love also the neighbour and to be well disposed towards him. Because, if we need to give thanks for those who are near, much more should we do it for those who draw near to us openly or in a hidden way, voluntarily or against their wishes, and also for those who seem to want to do damage to us: in fact God disposes everything for our good.

Therefore our every prayer should contain a thanksgiving. That if we have been ordered to pray not only for the faithful but also for the unfaithful, imagine what a great evil it would be to pray against the brothers!

Responsorial. *Ps. 70, 8 – 9. 23*

R: My mouth is full of your praise and your glory all day long. * Do not repel me in the time of my old age, do not abandon me when my strength declines.

V: Singing your praises, my lips and my life that you have ransomed will exult.

R: Do not repel me in the time of my old age, do not abandon me when my strength declines.

Gospel. *Mt. 24: 42 – 51*

Be ready.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Watch therefore, for you do not know on what day your Lord is coming. But know this, that if the householder had known in what part of the night the thief was coming, he would have watched and would not have let his house be broken into. Therefore you also must be ready; for the Son of man is coming at an hour you do not expect.

"Who then is the faithful and wise servant, whom his master has set over his household, to give them their food at the proper time? Blessed is that servant whom his master when he comes will find so doing. Truly, I say to you, he will set him over all his possessions. But if that wicked servant says to himself, 'My master is delayed,' and begins to beat his fellow servants, and eats and drinks with the drunken, the master of that servant will come on a day when he does not expect him and at an hour he does not know, and will punish him, and put him with the hypocrites; there men will weep and gnash their teeth.

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Eph. 6: 10 – 24*

The spiritual battle. Epilogue.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to the Ephesians.

Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. Put on the whole armour of God, that you may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil. For we are not contending against flesh and blood, but against the principalities, against the powers, against the world rulers of this present darkness, against the spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places.

Therefore take the whole armour of God, that you may be able to withstand in the evil day, and having done all, to stand.

Stand therefore, having girded your loins with truth, and having put on the breastplate of righteousness, and having shod your feet with the equipment of the gospel of peace; besides all these, taking the shield of faith, with which you can quench all the flaming darts of the evil one. And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God. Pray at all times in the Spirit, with all prayer and supplication. To that end keep alert with all perseverance, making supplication for all the saints, and also for me, that utterance may be given me in opening my mouth boldly to proclaim the mystery of the gospel, for which I am an ambassador in chains; that I may declare it boldly, as I ought to speak.

Now that you also may know how I am and what I am doing, Tych'icus the beloved brother and faithful minister in the Lord will tell you everything. I have sent him to you for this very purpose, that you may know how we are, and that he may encourage your hearts.

Peace be to the brethren, and love with faith, from God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. Grace be with all who love our Lord Jesus Christ with love undying.

Responsorial. *Ep. 6, 10 – 11; 1 Cor. 10, 13*

R: Draw strength from the Lord and in the vigour of his power. * Clothe yourselves with the armour of God, in order to resist the traps of the devil.

V: God is faithful and will not permit that you are tempted above your strength.

R: Clothe yourselves with the armour of God, in order to resist the traps of the devil.

Second Reading. C. 11

Let us clothe ourselves with the weapons of peace.

A reading from the treatise “Exhortations to the pagans” of Clement of Alexandria.

The truth cries out: “Let there be light shining out of darkness” (2Cor. 4, 6). Yes, the light shines out in the most intimate part of man, that is in his heart: and the rays of science spring forth to show with their splendour the interior man, the disciple of light, the familiar and “Co-heir of Christ” (Rm. 8, 17), above all when, as a good and pious son, he would learn to know the great and venerable name of the good Father, who commands gentle and healthy things for his own son. He who obeys him, comes out a victor in all things, follows God, obeys the Father; even though a sinner he has known him, he has loved God, he has loved his neighbour, he has fulfilled all that has been commanded him: he awaits the prize, certain of receiving that which has been promised to him. The plan of God has always been that of saving the flock of men: for this in his goodness he has sent the Good Shepherd. The Word then, after having revealed the truth, shows men the greatness of the redemption, in a way that induced to penance they may follow salvation, or, if they have not obeyed, they may merit condemnation.

This is the preaching of justice, which is an announcement of good for those who obey. For the others instead, who refuse to obey, it is a reason for condemnation.

A trumpet of war can reunite the soldiers and announce the battle with its loud sound; and will it not be rightful for Christ, who makes his sweet song of peace reach the extreme ends of the earth, to reunite his peaceful warriors? Know, O man, that he has truly gathered you, with his blood and with his word, an army of peace, to whom he has given the kingdom of heaven. The trumpet of Christ is his gospel. He himself has blown it and we have heard it. Let us strap on therefore the weapons of peace: clothe yourselves with the armour of justice and holding in your hand the shield of faith, let us take also the helmet of salvation and let us sharpen the sword of

the Spirit, that is the Word of God (cfr. Ep. 6, 13 – 17). In this attitude of peace does the Apostle dispose us; these are our weapons that make us invulnerable. Clothed with them let us remain firm in the battle against the adversary, so that we can “ put off all the flaming arrows of the evil one” (Ep. 6, 16) with the water given to us by the Word and exchange the benefits received with hymns of praise, honouring God by means of the divine Word. “ Then you will invoke him and he will answer you: Here I am!” (Is. 58, 9). Truly holy and blessed is this power, through which God lives with men. It is therefore necessary that man becomes the imitator and lover of that nature that is highly good and excellent. It is not right to imitate God in another way, than by honouring him in a holy way; nor can he be honoured and venerated if not by imitating him. For this the heavenly love, that is truly the love of God, unites itself to men when in the soul itself the true beauty kindled by the Word will shine forth. This happens at the highest level when salvation proceeds side by side with a sincere will; and the life is, so to say, tied by a free choice to the same yoke.

This exhortation of truth is the only thing that remains with us until the last breath, like a most faithful friend; and if someone tends towards heaven, it is the best guide of the soul, in order to reach an integral and perfect spirit. But to what does it exhort you? To your salvation. This is the will of Christ; and, in order to say everything with only one word: life is gifted to you.

But who is the Christ? Behold, briefly: he is the Word of truth, the Word that preserves from death and regenerates man bringing him back to the truth; he is the author of salvation, who has sent ruin far away, who has expelled death, has built a temple in men in order to put his dwelling of God in them. He makes this temple pure, and abandons to the wind and fire, like a falling flower, the voluptuousness and the feebleness. He wisely cultivates instead the fruit of temperance and consecrates your being to God as first fruits so that not only the work may be his, but also the grace of the work. Two things in fact are asked of the disciple of Christ: that he shows himself worthy of the kingdom and that he shows esteem for the kingdom itself.

Responsorial. *Ep. 6, 14. 15. 18*

R: Gird your loins with the truth, clothe yourselves with the armour of justice and with the zeal * for the propagation of the gospel of peace.

V: Pray incessantly with every type of prayer and intercession in the Spirit.

R: for the propagation of the gospel of peace.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *1 Tm. 3: 1 – 16*

The ministers of the Church.

A reading from the First Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Timothy.

The saying is sure: If any one aspires to the office of bishop, he desires a noble task. Now a bishop must be above reproach, the husband of one wife, temperate, sensible, dignified, hospitable, an apt teacher, no drunkard, not violent but gentle, not quarrelsome, and no lover of money.

He must manage his own household well, keeping his children submissive and respectful in every way; for if a man does not know how to manage his own household, how can he care for God's church? He must not be a recent convert, or he may be puffed up with conceit and fall into the condemnation of the devil; moreover he must be well thought of by outsiders, or he may fall into reproach and the snare of the devil.

Deacons likewise must be serious, not double-tongued, not addicted to much wine, not greedy for gain; they must hold the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. And let them also be tested first; then if they prove themselves blameless let them serve as deacons. The women likewise must be serious, no slanderers, but temperate, faithful in all things. Let deacons be the husband of one wife, and let them manage their children and their households well; for those who serve well as deacons gain a good standing for themselves and also great confidence in the faith which is in Christ Jesus.

I hope to come to you soon, but I am writing these instructions to you so that, if I am delayed, you may know how one ought to behave in the household of God, which is the church of the living God, the pillar and bulwark of the truth. Great indeed, we confess, is the mystery of our religion: He was manifested in the flesh, vindicated in the Spirit, seen by angels, preached among the nations, believed on in the world, taken up in glory.

Responsorial. *cfr. Act. 20, 28; 1 Cor. 4, 2*

R: Keep vigil over all the flock, in the midst of which the Holy Spirit has placed you as bishops * to guide the Church of God, acquired with the blood of his Son.

V: Faithfulness is asked of the one who has received the job of administrator.

R: to guide the Church of God, acquired with the blood of his Son.

Second Reading. Cc. 1, 1 – 3, 2; 4, 1 – 2; 6, 1; 7, 1 – 8,1

I want you to preserve yourselves like beloved children.

A reading from the “Letter to the Christians of Tralles” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

Ignatius, who is also called Theophorus, to the holy Church which is at Tralles, in Asia, beloved of God, the Father of Jesus Christ, elect, and worthy of God, possessing peace through the flesh, and blood, and passion of Jesus Christ, who is our hope, through our rising again to Him, which also I salute in its fullness, and in the apostolic character, and wish abundance of happiness. I know that you possess an irreproachable and sincere mind in patience, and that not only in present practice, but according to inherent nature, as Polybius your bishop has shown me. He has come to Smyrna by the will of God and Jesus Christ, and so sympathized in the joy which I, who am bound in Christ Jesus, possess, that I beheld your whole multitude in him. Having therefore received through him the testimony of your good will, according to God, I gloried to find you, as I knew you were the followers of God. In like manner, let all revere the deacons as an appointment of Jesus Christ, and the bishop as Jesus Christ, who is the Son of the Father, and the presbyters as the Sanhedrin of God, and assembly of the apostles. Apart from these, there is no Church. Concerning all this, I am persuaded that you are of the same opinion. For I have received the manifestations of your love, and still have it with me, in your bishop, whose very appearance is highly instructive, and his meekness of itself a power; whom I imagine even the ungodly must reverence, seeing they are also pleased that I do not spare myself. But shall I, when permitted to write on this point, reach such a height of self-esteem, that though being a condemned man, I should issue commands to you as if I were an apostle? I have great knowledge in God, but I restrain myself, lest, I should perish through boasting. For now it is needful for me to be the more fearful; and

not give heed to those that puff me up. For they that speak to me [in the way of commendation] scourge me. For I do indeed desire to suffer, but I know not if I be worthy to do so. For this longing, though it is not manifest to many, all the more vehemently assails me. I therefore have need of meekness, by which the prince of this world is brought to naught. I therefore, yet not I, but the love of Jesus Christ, entreat you that you use Christian nourishment only, and abstain from herbage of a different kind; I mean heresy. For those [that are given to this] mix up Jesus Christ with their own poison, speaking things which are unworthy of credit, like those who administer a deadly drug in sweet wine, which he who is ignorant of does greedily take, with a fatal pleasure leading to his own death. Be on your guard, therefore, against such persons. And this will be the case with you if you are not puffed up, and continue in intimate union with Jesus Christ our God, and the bishop, and the commands of the apostles. He that is within the altar is pure, but he that is without is not pure; that is, he who does anything apart from the bishop, and presbytery, and deacons, such a man is not pure in his conscience. Not that I know there is anything of this kind among you; but I put you on your guard, inasmuch as I love you greatly, and foresee the snares of the devil.

Responsorial. *Ep. 4, 3 – 6; 1 Cor. 3, 11*

R: Try to conserve the unity of the Spirit by means of the bonds of peace. Only one body, only one spirit, as only one is the hope to which you have been called, * only one Lord, only one faith, only one baptism.

V: No one can put a foundation that is different from that which has already been laid, which is Jesus Christ:

R: only one Lord, only one faith, and only one baptism.

Gospel. *Mt. 25: 1 – 13*

Behold the bridegroom. Go to meet him.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"Then the kingdom of heaven shall be compared to ten maidens who took their lamps and went to meet the bridegroom. Five of them were foolish, and five were wise. For when the foolish took their lamps, they took no oil with them; but the wise took flasks of oil with their lamps. As the bridegroom was delayed, they all slumbered and slept. But at midnight

there was a cry, 'Behold, the bridegroom! Come out to meet him.' Then all those maidens rose and trimmed their lamps. And the foolish said to the wise, 'Give us some of your oil, for our lamps are going out.' But the wise replied, 'Perhaps there will not be enough for us and for you; go rather to the dealers and buy for yourselves.' And while they went to buy, the bridegroom came, and those who were ready went in with him to the marriage feast; and the door was shut. Afterward the other maidens came also, saying, 'Lord, lord, open to us.' But he replied, 'Truly, I say to you, I do not know you.' Watch therefore, for you know neither the day nor the hour.

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Philemon. 1 – 25*

Intercession of the Apostle for Onesimus.

A reading from the Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Philemon.

Paul, a prisoner for Christ Jesus, and Timothy our brother, To Phile'mon our beloved fellow worker you our brother, and Ap'phia our sister and Archip'pus our fellow soldier, and the church in your house: Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

I thank my God always when I remember you in my prayers, because I hear of your love and of the faith which you have toward the Lord Jesus and all the saints, and I pray that the sharing of your faith may promote the knowledge of all the good that is ours in Christ. For I have derived much joy and comfort from your love, my brother, because the hearts of the saints have been refreshed through you.

Accordingly, though I am bold enough in Christ to command you to do what is required, yet for love's sake I prefer to appeal to you -- I, Paul, an ambassador and now a prisoner also for Christ Jesus -- I appeal to you for my child, Ones'imus, whose father I have become in my imprisonment. (Formerly he was useless to you, but now he is indeed useful to you and to me.)

I am sending him back to you, and with him – I would say- sending my very heart. I would have been glad to keep him with me, in order that he might serve me on your behalf during my imprisonment for the gospel; but I preferred to do nothing without your consent in order that your goodness might not be by compulsion but of your own free will. Perhaps this is why he was parted from you for a while, that you might have him back for ever, no longer as a slave but more than a slave, as a beloved brother, especially to me but how much more to you, both in the flesh and in the Lord. So if you consider me your partner, receive him as you would receive me. If he has wronged you at all, or owes you anything, charge that to my account. I, Paul, write this with my own hand, I will repay it -- to say nothing of your owing me even your own self. Yes, brother, I want some benefit from you

in the Lord. Refresh my heart in Christ. Confident of your obedience, I write to you, knowing that you will do even more than I say.

At the same time, prepare a guestroom for me, for I am hoping through your prayers to be granted to you. Ep'aphras, my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, sends greetings to you, and so do Mark, Aristar'chus, Demas, and Luke, my fellow workers. The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit.

Responsorial. *Gal. 3, 28: 4, 7; Philemon 17, 16*

R: All of you are one in Christ Jesus. * Therefore you are not anymore slave, but son, and if you are son, you are also heir by the will of God.

V: Welcome him not any more as a slave, but as a dear brother.

R: Therefore you are not anymore slave, but son, and if you are son, you are also heir by the will of God.

Second Reading. *Nm. 5 – 6*

Let us follow the new life in Christ by means of the Spirit.

A reading from the “Discourse on baptism” of St. Pacian, bishop.

The sin of Adam had passed to the whole human race: “By one man sin entered into this world and by sin death: and so death passed upon all men.” The justice of Christ, then, had to pass on to the entire human race.

And just as Adam had caused the destruction of his descendants by sin, so Christ, by his justice, would bring life to the whole human race. The Apostle makes the point, saying. “For as by the disobedience of one man, many were made sinners; so also by the obedience of one many shall be made just...as sin has reigned to death, so also grace might reign by justice unto life everlasting through Jesus Christ our Lord.”

Someone, perhaps, will object: The sin of Adam deservedly passed to posterity because they were born his descendants. But how are we born from Christ so that we can be saved through him? If you stop thinking in terms of the flesh you will understand our birth from Christ and his paternity in our regard. In these last days Christ took a soul and body in the womb of Mary. It is this flesh which he has come to save. He did not abandon it in hell, but joined it to his own spirit, making it his own. This is the marriage of the Lord, joined in the flesh of man – a great mystery uniting the two – Christ and the Church – in one flesh. This marriage,

under the influence of the Holy Spirit, come down from heaven, has given birth to the people of God. Thanks to a heavenly seed inserted in the substance of our souls, we take form in the womb of our spiritual mother and, once we issue from her womb, we are vivified in Christ. And so the apostle says: “The first man, Adam, became a living soul; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit.” It is thus by his priests that Christ engenders life in the Church, as the apostle confirms: “for in Christ Jesus did I beget you.” It is the seed of Christ, that is to say the Spirit of God, which produces through the priest’s hands the new man, conceived in the womb of his mother and born in the baptismal font under the auspices of faith.

We must receive Christ so that he may give us birth, as John the apostle says: To as many as received him, he gave the power of becoming sons of God.” But this cannot be brought about without the bath of water and the sacrament of anointing which the bishop administers. The bath of water purifies us from our sins. The holy anointing pours down the Holy Spirit on us. This double blessing we obtain through the actions and words of the bishop.

So, it is the whole man that is reborn and renewed in Christ, in order that, just as Christ has arisen from the dead through the glory of the Father so we also may walk in newness of life, in other words, we must reject our former vices in order to practise a new Christian morality by the Spirit

Responsorial. *cfr. Rm. 5, 19. 21; 1 Jn 4, 10*

R: Through the disobedience of one man, all are sinners; through the obedience of one man, all will be just. * Just as sin reigned wherever there was death, so grace will reign to bring eternal life, in Christ Jesus.

V: God has sent his Son as the victim of expiation for our sins.

R: Just as sin reigned wherever there was death, so grace will reign to bring eternal life, in Christ Jesus.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *1 Tm. 4: 1 – 5:2*

The bishop, master of the sound doctrine and man of piety.

A reading from the first Letter of St. Paul, apostle, to Timothy.

Now the Spirit expressly says that in later times some will depart from the faith by giving heed to deceitful spirits and doctrines of demons, through the pretensions of liars whose consciences are seared, who forbid marriage and enjoin abstinence from foods which God created to be received with thanksgiving by those who believe and know the truth. For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving; for then it is consecrated by the word of God and prayer. If you put these instructions before the brethren, you will be a good minister of Christ Jesus, nourished on the words of the faith and of the good doctrine that you have followed. Have nothing to do with godless and silly myths. Train yourself in godliness; for while bodily training is of some value, godliness is of value in every way, as it holds promise for the present life and also for the life to come. The saying is sure and worthy of full acceptance. For to this end we toil and strive, because we have our hope set on the living God, who is the Saviour of all men, especially of those who believe. Command and teach these things.

Let no one despise your youth, but set the believers an example in speech and conduct, in love, in faith, in purity. Till I come, attend to the public reading of scripture, to preaching, to teaching. Do not neglect the gift you have, which was given you by prophetic utterance when the council of elders laid their hands upon you. Practice these duties, devote yourself to them, so that all may see your progress. Take heed to yourself and to your teaching; hold to that, for by so doing you will save both yourself and your hearers.

Do not rebuke an older man but exhort him as you would a father; treat younger men like brothers, older women like mothers, younger women like sisters, in all purity.

Responsorial. *cfr. 1 Tm. 4, 8. 10; 2 Cor. 4, 9*

R: Piety is useful to all, and brings with it the promise of life. We struggle and fight, * because we have placed our hope in the living God.

V: Persecuted, but not abandoned; struck down but not killed,

R: because we have placed our hope in the living God.

Second Reading. *Cc. 8,1 – 9,2; 11, 1- 13,3*

You will be reborn in faith that is the flesh of the Lord

and in charity that is his blood.

A reading from the “Letter to the Christians of Tralles” of St. Ignatius of Antioch, bishop and martyr.

Wherefore, clothing yourselves with meekness, be renewed in faith, that is the flesh of the Lord, and in love, that is the blood of Jesus Christ. Let no one of you cherish any grudge against his neighbour. Give no occasion to the Gentiles, lest by means of a few foolish men the whole multitude [of those that believe] in God be evil spoken of. For, “Woe to him by whose vanity my name is blasphemed among any.” Stop your ears, therefore, when any one speaks to you at variance with Jesus Christ, who was descended from David, and was also of Mary; who was truly born, and did eat and drink. He was truly persecuted under Pontius Pilate; He was truly crucified, and [truly] died, in the sight of beings in heaven, and on earth, and under the earth. He was also truly raised from the dead, His Father raising Him, even as after the same manner His Father will so raise up we who believe in Him by Christ Jesus, apart from whom we do not possess the true life. Flee, therefore, those evil offshoots [of Satan], which produce death-bearing fruit, whereof if any one tastes, he instantly dies. For these men are not the planting of the Father. For if they were, they would appear as branches of the cross, and their fruit would be incorruptible. By it He calls you through His passion, as being His members. The head, therefore, cannot be born by itself, without its members; God, who is [the Saviour] Himself, having promised their union. I salute you from Smyrna, together with the Churches of God which are with me, who have comforted me in all things, both in the flesh and in the spirit. My bonds, which I carry about with me for the sake of Jesus Christ (praying that I may attain to God), exhort you. Continue in harmony among yourselves, and in prayer with one another; for it becomes every one of you, and especially the presbyters, to comfort the bishop, to the honour of the Father, of Jesus Christ, and of the apostles. I entreat you in love to hear me, that I may not, by having written, be a testimony against you. And do you also pray for me, who have need of your love, along with the mercy of God, that I may be worthy of the lot for which I am destined, and that I may not be found reprobate. The love of the Smyrnaeans and Ephesians salutes you. Remember in your prayers the Church that is in Syria, from which also I am not worthy to receive my name, being the last of them. Fare you well in

Jesus Christ, while you continue subject to the bishop, as to the command [of God], and in like manner to the presbyterate. And do you, every man, love one another with an undivided heart. Let my spirit be sanctified by yours, not only now, but also when I shall attain to God. For I am as yet exposed to danger. But the Father is faithful in Jesus Christ to fulfil both mine and your petitions: in whom may you be found without fault.

Responsorial. *cfr. 2 Th. 2, 14 – 15; Sir. 15, 13*

R: God has called you through the gospel, to possess the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ. * Therefore be firm and maintain the traditions that you have learned.

V: The Lord hates all abominations; it is not wanted by he who fears the Lord.

R: Therefore be firm and maintain the traditions that you have learned.

Gospel. *Mt. 25: 14 – 30*

*You have been faithful in little:
take part in the joy of your master.*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"For it will be as when a man going on a journey called his servants and entrusted to them his property; to one he gave five talents, to another two, to another one, to each according to his ability. Then he went away.

He who had received the five talents went at once and traded with them; and he made five talents more. So also, he who had the two talents made two talents more. But he who had received the one talent went and dug in the ground and hid his master's money. Now after a long time the master of those servants came and settled accounts with them. And he who had received the five talents came forward, bringing five talents more, saying, 'Master, you delivered to me five talents; here I have made five talents more.' His master said to him, 'Well done, good and faithful servant; you have been faithful over a little, I will set you over much; enter into the joy of your master.' And he also who had the two talents came forward, saying, 'Master, you delivered to me two talents; here I have made two talents more.' His master said to him, 'Well done, good and faithful servant; you have been faithful over a little, I will set you over much; enter into the joy of your master.' He also who had received the one talent came forward,

saying, 'Master, I knew you to be a hard man, reaping where you did not sow, and gathering where you did not winnow; so I was afraid, and I went and hid your talent in the ground. Here you have what is yours.' But his master answered him, 'You wicked and slothful servant! You knew that I reap where I have not sowed, and gather where I have not winnowed? Then you ought to have invested my money with the bankers, and at my coming I should have received what was my own with interest. So take the talent from him, and give it to him who has the ten talents. For to every one who has will more be given, and he will have abundance; but from him who has not, even what he has will be taken away. And cast the worthless servant into the outer darkness; there men will weep and gnash their teeth.'